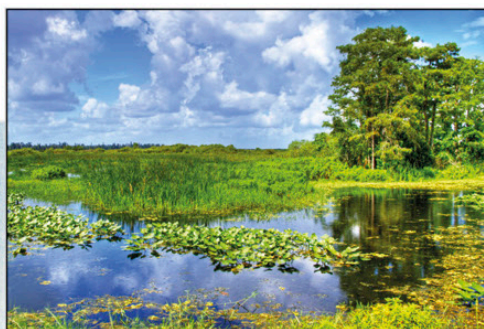
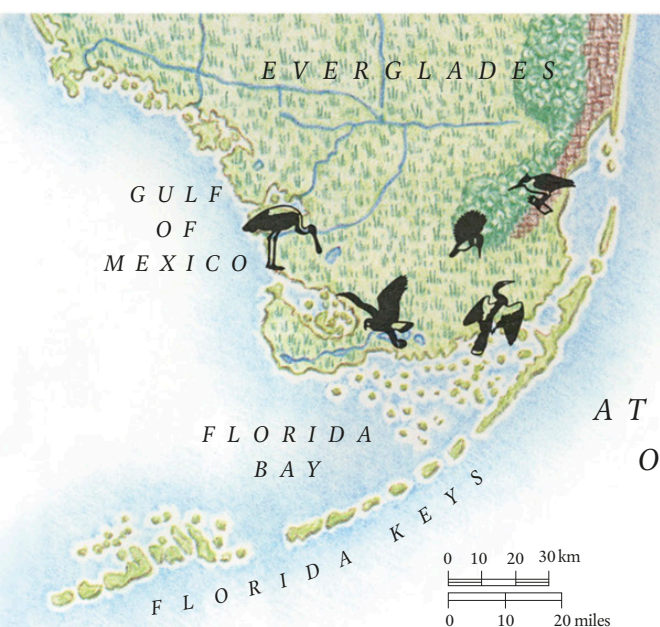


The Everglades

The tropical swamps of the Everglades National Park in southern Florida are home to a unique variety of birds. Many migrating birds stop and rest here, too. The whole area is only just above sea level and consists of a huge swamp covered with sedges, grasses, and rushes. Deeper channels of open water run through it. These contain islands of trees called hummocks. Along the coast, belts of mangrove trees trap mud and silt with their roots and build up new land. The birds feed on the variety of insects and fish that live in this warm, humid environment.



In the swampy waters of the Everglades, islands of trees occur on slightly higher ground. The dense plant growth gives protection from storms and floods.

Snail kite

This unusual kite feeds mainly on water snails. It flaps slowly over the swamps on its large, wide wings. When it spots a snail, it swoops down, grabs the snail in one foot, and carries it to a perch. Then it uses its thin, hooked bill to pull out the body of the snail without breaking the shell. Snail kites in the Everglades were once near extinction but are now protected.



Snail kite
(*Rostrhamus sociabilis*)
Length: 1 ft 7 in (48 cm)

Long, hooked upper bill

Male has red legs; female and young have orange legs.

ATLANTIC OCEAN

Roseate spoonbill
(*Platalea ajaja*)
Length: 2 ft 10 in (86.5 cm)

Roseate spoonbill

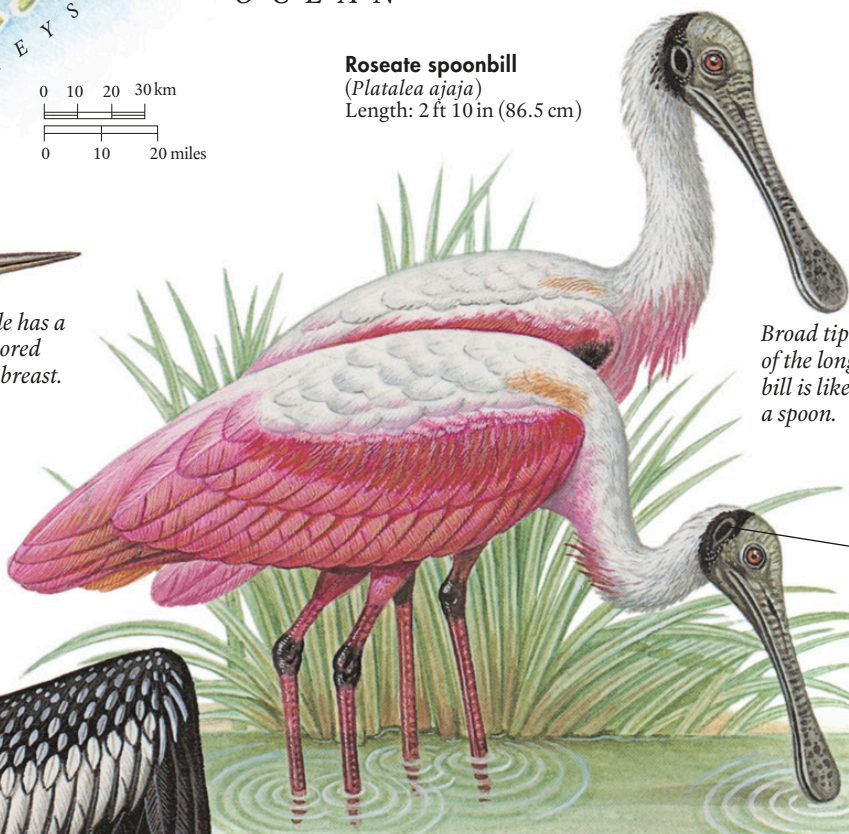
Spoonbills have elaborate courtship displays, including clapping bills and giving each other twigs. To catch food, the spoonbill sweeps its sensitive bill from side to side through the water. When it feels food, such as fish, it snaps its bill quickly shut. Spoonbills were once hunted for their feathers, which were used to decorate hats. They are now protected and their numbers have grown.



Anhinga
(*Anhinga anhinga*)
Length: 3 ft (91 cm)

The female has a tawny colored neck and breast.

Large, broad wings are spread out to dry in the sun.



Broad tip of the long bill is like a spoon.

Ear opening on the side of the head

Green-backed heron

The shy green-backed heron feeds mainly at night and hides among waterside plants by day. But it has adapted well to living in urban areas near people. This wading bird grabs fish and small animals in its long, strong bill and will sometimes dive underwater to chase its prey.

Crest is raised when the bird is excited.



The green-backed heron often crouches, silent and still, at the edge of water to spot its prey.

Green-backed heron
(*Butorides striata*)
Length: 1 ft 7 in (48 cm)

Anhinga

The anhinga often swims on the surface with just its head and neck showing, so it looks like a snake. It dives deep under the water to catch fish, spearing them with its daggerlike bill. The jagged edges of its bill help the anhinga keep a firm hold on its prey, until it can flip it up into the air and swallow it whole.